CHAPTER 7 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

Andersonville

Inside the Confederacy's most notorious prison camp, where thousands of Union soldiers died of hunger and disease. 1864–1865.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Inside the Confederacy's most notorious prison camp, where thousands of Union soldiers died of hunger and disease. 1864–1865.

When a place produces unbearable suffering, how does a historian decide what — and who — was to blame?

A Camp Built to Overflow

1864

As prisoner exchanges broke down in 1864, both sides crowded captured soldiers into camps neither could properly feed. The worst was Andersonville, in Georgia — a stockade built for about 10,000 men that was soon packed with more than 30,000.

There was little shelter, foul water, and almost no medicine. A line inside the fence called the “dead line” marked a boundary: cross it, and guards would shoot.

Andersonville Prison, Georgia — the overcrowded stockade — photograph, August 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

Inside the Stockade

A. J. RIDDLE · AUGUST 1864

This photograph shows the camp at its deadliest, packed with makeshift tents called ‘shebangs.’ Of the roughly 45,000 men held here, nearly 13,000 died.

Andersonville Prison, Georgia — photograph by A. J. Riddle, August 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

~13,000

THE TOLL AT ANDERSONVILLE

Of the roughly 45,000 Union prisoners held at Andersonville over 14 months, nearly 13,000 died — most from disease, exposure, and starvation.

That is a death rate of almost 29%. Survivors came home as living skeletons, and their photographs shocked the North as deeply as the images of the battlefield dead.

A released Union prisoner from Andersonville — photograph, 1865, public domain (U.S. National Archives).

What Starvation Did

AFTER RELEASE · 1865

Photographs of released prisoners, published after the war, horrified the North and fueled demands that someone be held to account for the camp.

A released Union prisoner from Andersonville — photograph, 1865, public domain (U.S. National Archives).

Who Was Responsible?

THE RECKONING

After the war, the camp's commander, Captain Henry Wirz, was tried and executed — one of the only people executed for war crimes after the Civil War. But historians still debate the fuller question.

Was Andersonville the result of deliberate cruelty? Of a collapsing Confederacy that could not feed its own soldiers, let alone prisoners? Of the breakdown of prisoner exchanges on both sides? Assigning blame means weighing evidence carefully — and resisting easy answers.

Relics of Andersonville — the "Dead Line" post and prison mail box — photograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

A SURVIVING PRISONER, RECALLING ANDERSONVILLE

There was no shade … no shelter from the burning sun or the drenching rain. … Men died at the rate of a hundred a day, and we buried them in long trenches, side by side.

Suffering, Evidence, and Judgment

WHY IT MATTERS

Andersonville forces two historian's habits at once. Historical empathy asks us to understand the real human suffering behind the numbers — without turning it into a horror story for its own sake. And careful use of evidence asks us to assign responsibility fairly, weighing cruelty against collapse.

Both sides' prisons were deadly; Andersonville was the worst. Holding both facts at once — real atrocity, and real complexity — is what mature historical thinking looks like.

Andersonville Prison, Georgia — the overcrowded stockade — photograph, August 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

Weigh the Evidence Fairly

YOUR TURN

You'll read the photograph and survivor testimony together and practice historical empathy and evidence — understanding the suffering, then judging responsibility without rushing to the easiest answer.